Chapter 35

Interactive Dashboards

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35.1 Learning objectives

After completing this chapter, you will be able to:

- Create a Quarto dashboard layout with multiple panels and pages
- Convert ggplot2 figures to interactive plotly charts
- Build searchable, filterable data tables with the DT package
- Design effective dashboard layouts for bibliometric data exploration
- Deploy dashboards as self-contained HTML files

35.2 Setup

```
library(tidyverse)
library(openalexR)
library(plotly)
library(DT)
library(glue)

set.seed(20260509)

source(here::here("R", "api_helpers.R"))
source(here::here("R", "utils.R"))
source(here::here("R", "sci_palette.R"))
```

35.3 Conceptual background

Bibliometric analysis often produces more data than can be communicated through static figures and tables. Interactive dashboards allow stakeholders — research managers, librarians, policy makers — to explore data on their own terms: filtering by year, hovering for details, sorting tables, and drilling down into specific subsets.

Quarto dashboards use the `format: dashboard` output type to arrange content in cards, rows, and columns. They support static and interactive content side by side, and can be deployed as self-contained HTML files (no server needed) or as server-backed applications.

plotly converts ggplot2 figures into interactive JavaScript visualisations with hover tooltips, zooming, panning, and selection. The `ggplotly()` function provides a zero-effort upgrade path from static to interactive figures, though fine-tuning often requires direct plotly syntax.

DT (DataTables) renders data frames as interactive HTML tables with search, sort, pagination, and filtering. For bibliometric data, DT is invaluable: users can search for specific authors, sort by citation count, and filter by year — all without writing code.

The key design principle for dashboards is **progressive disclosure**: show the most important summary first, then let users drill down into details. Avoid overwhelming users with every metric at once.

35.4 Worked example

35.4.1 Preparing dashboard data

```
works <- fetch_openalex(
  entity = "works",
  primary_location.source.id = "S148561398",
  from_publication_date = "2019-01-01",
  to_publication_date = "2023-12-31",
  options = list(sample = 500, seed = 42)
)

dash_data <- works |>
  transmute(
    id, title = display_name,
    year = year(publication_date),
    cited_by_count, oa_status, type, source_display_name
  )
```

```
cat(glue("Dashboard data: {nrow(dash_data)} records\n"))
```

```
#> Dashboard data: 500 records
```

35.4.2 Interactive trend chart

```
# Interactive plotly widget — only rendered for HTML output.
trend <- dash_data |>
  count(year)

p <- ggplot(trend, aes(x = year, y = n)) +
  geom_line(colour = palette_sci(1), linewidth = 1) +
  geom_point(colour = palette_sci(1), size = 3) +
  labs(x = "Year", y = "Publications") +
  theme_sci()

ggplotly(p)
```

35.4.3 Interactive citation distribution

```
# Interactive plotly widget — only rendered for HTML output.
p2 <- ggplot(dash_data, aes(x = cited_by_count)) +
  geom_histogram(binwidth = 5, fill = palette_sci(1), colour =
  ↪  "white") +
  labs(x = "Citation count", y = "Papers") +
  theme_sci()

ggplotly(p2)
```

35.4.4 Searchable data table

```
# Interactive DT widget — only rendered for HTML output.
dash_data |>
  select(title, year, cited_by_count, oa_status) |>
  arrange(desc(cited_by_count)) |>
  datatable(
    options = list(pageLength = 10, searchHighlight = TRUE),
    filter = "top",
```

```
    rownames = FALSE
  )
```

35.4.5 OA status breakdown (interactive)

```
# Interactive plotly widget — only rendered for HTML output.
oa_trend <- dash_data |>
  count(year, oa_status)

p3 <- ggplot(oa_trend, aes(x = factor(year), y = n, fill =
 ↪  oa_status)) +
  geom_col() +
  scale_fill_manual(values =
   ↪  palette_sci(n_distinct(oa_trend$oa_status))) +
  labs(x = "Year", y = "Count", fill = "OA Status") +
  theme_sci()

ggplotly(p3)
```

35.5 Diagnostics and interpretation

- **Performance**: Large datasets (> 10,000 rows) can make plotly and DT slow. Aggregate or sample data before rendering interactive widgets.
- **Accessibility**: Interactive figures are not accessible to screen readers. Always provide alt text and consider static fallbacks.
- **File size**: Self-contained HTML dashboards embed all data and JavaScript libraries. Files can reach 5–50 MB for complex dashboards.
- **Browser compatibility**: Test in Chrome, Firefox, and Safari. Some plotly features render differently across browsers.

35.6 Limitations and responsible use

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- **Interactivity is not analysis.** A dashboard lets users explore data, but exploration without statistical rigour can produce misleading impressions. Pair dashboards with proper analysis.

- **Dashboards can mislead.** Default axis ranges, binning, and colour choices affect interpretation. Design dashboards to prevent misreading, not enable it.
- **Data privacy.** Interactive tables may expose individual-level data (author names, paper titles). Consider whether the dashboard's audience should see this level of detail.
- **Maintenance burden.** Dashboards that query live APIs need updating when APIs change. Static dashboards based on cached data are more sustainable (Hicks et al., 2015).

35.8 Common pitfalls

35.9 Common pitfalls

- **Too many widgets.** A dashboard with 15 interactive panels is overwhelming. Start with 3–5 and add more only if users need them.
- **Not filtering large datasets.** Rendering 50,000 rows in DT or 100,000 points in plotly will crash the browser. Pre-aggregate.
- **Ignoring PDF fallbacks.** If your Quarto book renders to PDF, interactive widgets become static. Ensure the static version is still informative.
- **Using ggplotly without cleanup.** `ggplotly()` produces verbose tooltips. Customise hover text with `tooltip` parameter or direct plotly.

35.10 Exercises

1. **Multi-page dashboard.** Create a Quarto dashboard (format: dashboard) with two pages: "Overview" (trend + citation distribution) and "Details" (searchable table).
2. **Linked brushing.** Use plotly's selection features to highlight papers in a scatter plot and simultaneously filter a DT table below.
3. **Custom tooltips.** Modify the trend chart to show "Year: 2023, Papers: 87, Mean cites: 12.3" on hover instead of the default tooltip.

35.11 Solutions

Solutions are provided in E.

35.12 Further reading

- Aria and Cuccurullo (2017) — `bibliometrix` and `biblioshiny` for interactive bibliometric exploration.
- Priem et al. (2022) — OpenAlex as a data source for dashboard construction.

35.13 Session info

```
sessionInfo()
```

```
#> R version 4.6.1 (2026-06-24)
#> Platform: x86_64-pc-linux-gnu
#> Running under: Ubuntu 24.04.5 LTS
#>
#> Matrix products: default
#> BLAS:
 ↪  /usr/lib/x86_64-linux-gnu/openblas-pthread/libblas.so.3
#> LAPACK: /usr/lib/x86_64-linux-gnu/openblas-pthread/libopenbl
 ↪  asp-r0.3.26.so;  LAPACK version 3.12.0
#>
#> locale:
#>  [1] LC_CTYPE=C.UTF-8       LC_NUMERIC=C
 ↪  LC_TIME=C.UTF-8
#>  [4] LC_COLLATE=C.UTF-8     LC_MONETARY=C.UTF-8
 ↪  LC_MESSAGES=C.UTF-8
#>  [7] LC_PAPER=C.UTF-8      LC_NAME=C              LC_ADDRESS=C
#> [10] LC_TELEPHONE=C         LC_MEASUREMENT=C.UTF-8
 ↪  LC_IDENTIFICATION=C
#>
#> time zone: UTC
#> tzcode source: system (glibc)
#>
#> attached base packages:
#> [1] stats     graphics  grDevices utils     datasets  methods
 ↪  base
#>
#> other attached packages:
#>  [1] DT_0.34.0                plotly_4.12.1
#>  [3] uwot_0.2.5               Matrix_1.7-5
#>  [5] word2vec_0.4.1           stm_1.3.8
#>  [7] topicmodels_0.2-17       quanteda.textstats_0.97.2
#>  [9] visNetwork_2.1.4         ggraph_2.2.2
#> [11] tidygraph_1.3.1          igraph_2.3.4
```

```
#> [13] quanteda_4.5.1            pdftools_3.9.1
#> [15] arrow_26.0.0              bibliometrix_5.5.0
#> [17] RefManageR_1.4.0          bib2df_1.1.2.0
#> [19] rcrossref_1.2.1           gt_1.4.0
#> [21] tidytext_0.4.3            glue_1.8.1
#> [23] openalexR_3.1.2           lubridate_1.9.5
#> [25] forcats_1.0.1             stringr_1.6.0
#> [27] dplyr_1.2.1               purrr_1.2.2
#> [29] readr_2.2.0               tidyr_1.3.2
#> [31] tibble_3.3.1              ggplot2_4.0.3
#> [33] tidyverse_2.0.0
#>
#> loaded via a namespace (and not attached):
#>   [1] bibtex_0.5.3           RColorBrewer_1.1-3
 ↪  rstudioapi_0.19.0
#>   [4] jsonlite_2.0.0         magrittr_2.0.5
 ↪  modeltools_0.2-25
#>   [7] farver_2.1.2           rmarkdown_2.32         fs_2.1.0
#>  [10] vctrs_0.7.3            memoise_2.0.1
 ↪  askpass_1.2.1
#>  [13] base64enc_0.1-6        htmltools_0.5.9
 ↪  contentanalysis_1.1.1
#>  [16] curl_8.1.0             broom_1.0.13
 ↪  janeaustenr_1.0.0
#>  [19] cellranger_1.1.0       htmlwidgets_1.6.4
 ↪  tokenizers_0.3.0
#>  [22] plyr_1.8.9           httr2_1.3.0          cachem_1.1.0
#>  [25] dimensionsR_0.0.3      mime_0.13
 ↪  lifecycle_1.0.5
#>  [28] pkgconfig_2.0.3        R6_2.6.1
 ↪  fastmap_1.2.0
#>  [31] shiny_1.14.0           digest_0.6.39
 ↪  patchwork_1.3.2
#>  [34] shinycssloaders_1.1.0  rprojroot_2.1.1
 ↪  RSpectra_0.16-2
#>  [37] SnowballC_0.7.1        labeling_0.4.3
 ↪  urltools_1.7.3.1
#>  [40] timechange_0.4.0       mgcv_1.9-4             httr_1.4.9
#>  [43] polyclip_1.10-7        compiler_4.6.1         here_1.0.2
#>  [46] bit64_4.8.6            withr_3.0.3
 ↪  backports_1.5.1
#>  [49] S7_0.2.2               viridis_0.6.5
 ↪  ggforce_0.5.0
#>  [52] MASS_7.3-65          bibliometrixData_0.3.0 tools_4.6.1
#>  [55] otel_0.2.0             stopwords_2.3          zip_3.0.2
#>  [58] rentrez_1.2.4          httpuv_1.6.17
 ↪  nlme_3.1-169
#>  [61] promises_1.5.0         grid_4.6.1
 ↪  stringdist_0.9.17
#>  [64] reshape2_1.4.5         generics_0.1.4
 ↪  gtable_0.3.6
```

```
#>  [67] tzdb_0.5.0             rscopus_0.9.0          ca_0.72
#>  [70] data.table_1.18.6.1    hms_1.1.4              xml2_1.6.0
#>  [73] utf8_1.2.6             ggrepel_0.9.8
 ↪  pillar_1.11.1
#>  [76] nsyllable_1.0.1        vroom_1.7.1            later_1.4.8
#>  [79] splines_4.6.1          tweenr_2.0.3
 ↪  lattice_0.22-9
#>  [82] FNN_1.1.4.1            bit_4.6.0
 ↪  tidyselect_1.2.1
#>  [85] tm_0.7-20              miniUI_0.1.2           knitr_1.52
#>  [88] gridExtra_2.3.1        NLP_0.3-3
 ↪  bookdown_0.48
#>  [91] stats4_4.6.1           crul_1.6.0             xfun_0.62
#>  [94] graphlayouts_1.2.5     matrixStats_1.5.0
 ↪  humaniformat_0.6.0
#>  [97] stringi_1.8.9          qpdf_1.4.1             yaml_2.3.12
#> [100] evaluate_1.0.5         httpcode_0.3.0         cli_3.6.6
#> [103] xtable_1.8-8           systemfonts_1.3.2      Rcpp_1.1.2
#> [106] readxl_1.6.0           triebeard_0.4.1
 ↪  XML_3.99-0.25
#> [109] parallel_4.6.1         assertthat_0.2.1
 ↪  pubmedR_1.0.2
#> [112] slam_0.1-56            viridisLite_0.4.3
 ↪  scales_1.4.0
#> [115] crayon_1.5.3           openxlsx_4.2.9         rlang_1.3.0
#> [118] fastmatch_1.1-8
```